

Checklist:

Feedback Checklist

Before the work starts

- ☐ Explain what success looks like
- ☐ Define what a strong result looks like versus a weak one
- ☐ Share advice for getting started well
- ☐ Point out common pitfalls to avoid
- ☐ Set expectations early, not only after problems appear

Give feedback regularly

- ☐ Give feedback frequently, not just during reviews
- ☐ Comment on recent work while it is still fresh
- ☐ Balance praise with improvement feedback
- ☐ Include feedback on skills, growth, and career trajectory, not only tasks

Make feedback specific

- ☐ Describe the exact behavior, action, or output
- ☐ Use concrete examples
- ☐ Explain why it was effective or ineffective
- ☐ Avoid vague statements like “this was confusing” without details

Include behavioral feedback

- ☐ Look for patterns across multiple situations
- ☐ Share observations about habits, tendencies, and working style
- ☐ Support behavioral feedback with examples
- ☐ Deliver this thoughtfully, since it feels more personal

Gather multiple perspectives

- ☐ Collect input from others when useful
- ☐ Use 360-style feedback for a fuller picture
- ☐ Ask collaborators what the person should do more of
- ☐ Ask collaborators what the person should change or stop doing

Check whether the feedback is being heard

- ☐ Make the other person feel safe enough to listen
- ☐ Show that your goal is to help, not attack
- ☐ Ask for their perspective
- ☐ Confirm understanding by asking for takeaways and next steps
- ☐ Follow up in writing when clarity would help

Make it actionable

- ☐ Clarify what success looks and feels like
- ☐ Suggest next steps when appropriate
- ☐ Be clear whether you are setting an expectation or making a suggestion
- ☐ Leave room for the other person to think through solutions too

Deliver critical feedback well

- ☐ Address the issue directly and calmly
- ☐ Focus on the work or behavior, not the person's character
- ☐ Avoid accusatory or emotionally loaded language
- ☐ Do not give critical feedback while upset
- ☐ State the concern plainly
- ☐ Explain what led you to that concern
- ☐ Invite the other person's perspective
- ☐ Discuss how to resolve it together

Avoid common mistakes

- ☐ Don't wait until review time to raise serious issues
- ☐ Don't assume task feedback alone is enough
- ☐ Don't hide the message in a "compliment sandwich."
- ☐ Don't make the conversation so soft that the real issue is unclear

- ☐ Don't present decisions as a discussion if they are already made

Final test

- ☐ Is this feedback likely to improve things?
- ☐ Is it clear, fair, timely, and respectful?
- ☐ Does the person know what to do next?